sure I knew what he expected from me. And he gave me the information or advice I needed to make sure I was up to that.

He takes whatever time he needs with each of his players. And that tells you he values what every single player can bring to the team. By the autumn of 2001, I'd already known the manager for a very long time: his experience, though, meant I was still learning from him almost every day. Look at his record, at United and, before then, at Aberdeen. The idea of him not being there was going to take some getting used to. Like everybody else inside and outside Old Trafford, I couldn't help wondering who could replace him.

There are great managers around and lots of them—like Martin O'Neill of Celtic and Giovanni Trapattoni of Italy and even Sven-Goran Eriksson—were talked about for the United job. At Old Trafford, though, the job would take more than the right CV. Any new manager would have to be like the boss is: a man with a mission. It's why so many people admire him so much. It's also why he gets under the skin of so many others. Whatever the manager says or does, it's never: I want this for Alex Ferguson. It's always: I want this for the club. He is Manchester United, through and through. Anyone who cares about United, anyone who really understands soccer, recognizes that. Even after we'd won the Treble, although he recognized what an achievement it was for us as a group of players, he was immediately thinking about the future. About the need to go on and match what we'd just done and then better it next time round.

The desire to bring success to Old Trafford was what had driven every single one of us on; for the best part of fifteen years, in the case of me and the Nevilles, Paul Scholes, Ryan Giggs and Nicky Butt. The boss, though, was always more intense than anyone: never sitting still, always concentrating on the next challenge. I'd say his drive was more important to our success than anything else. He didn't spend too much time saying it in public, but the players knew the boss valued what we'd achieved. In my case, I was sure he recognized—back then, anyway—that, whatever else was going on in the rest of my life, I would never let United down through lack of effort. Above everything, I was a Manchester United player. Since I'd arrived at Old Trafford, of course, that had meant working for the boss.

Early on in 2001/02, our form was up and down. Lots of pundits jumped to the conclusion that uncertainty about the manager was the explanation. There were all sorts of rumors that we got to hear about, like that the boss regretted having had to tell us he was leaving because it meant we weren't frightened of him any more. I can honestly say that wasn't true. None of us